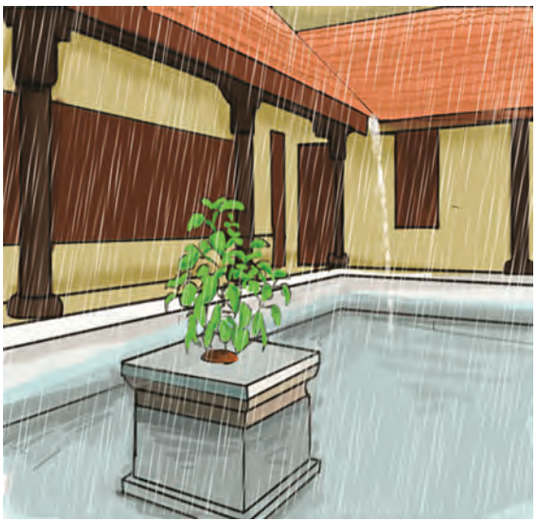
'I wonder whether it's a cyclone . . . The sound of it scares me,' said **Ammamma**. She asked all of us to sit down in the middle room upstairs and gave us metal dice to play with. Since the light had grown dim, she lit a brass lamp as well. **Muthassi** called out from the **thekkini**, the southern room, downstairs, 'Have you closed all the small windows, Kochu?' 'I' ll close them, Amme; I'll close all of them,' answered Ammamma. We suddenly heard the sound of the rain from the south-west, like the roar of a vast crowd of people. Using all her force, Ammamma slammed the windows shut. Raindrops glimmered on her face.

'It's not even four, but it's pitch dark outside,' said Ammamma.'I want to see Kutti Oppu,' said Malathikutty. 'She'll come by dusk,' said Ammamma.'I want to go to Ambazhathel now, this minute,' said Malathikutty. 'I'll send you to Ambazhathel as soon as the storm stops.' Ammamma tried to comfort her, but Malathikutty began to sob loudly. That was when we heard a coconut palm crashing down. 'Kochu, what was that? Will the house collapse?' That was Muthassi.

'Don't worry. It was a coconut palm falling. We'll go and have a look at it once the rain stops. Let's say our prayers and sit here quietly', said Ammamma. All of us took shelter in the southern room downstairs as Ammaman's mother instructed us to do.



She said this room had the strongest ceiling. The thekkini was flooded and the water that had collected in the sunken courtyard of the nalukettu, the central hall with four wooden pillars, began to overflow. **Ammaman** and all of us sat on the bed. Ammamma and the grandmothers sat on the rolled-up mattresses stacked on the floor. And the servant woman took refuge in the makeshift toilet adjacent to the room.

Ammayi arrived, drenched to the skin, unmindful of the thunder and lightning and driving rain. 'How can you be so foolish, Bala? What if you fall ill of a fever?' asked Ammaman. **Ammayi** laughed. 'Here's Kutti Oppu,' exclaimed Malathikutty joyfully. Ammayi hugged her.

Cheriamma suggested that we chant aksharaslokams to forget our fear: each one of us would have to recite a verse and the next person would follow with a verse that began with the first letter of the third line of the quatrain that had just been chanted. No one volunteered, though. So Cheriamma recited from Vallathol's Imprisoned Aniruddhan. Ammamma said, 'I can't remember a single couplet.' 'I hope the house doesn't collapse,' murmured Muthassi.

As soon as Ammaman and Ammayi went upstairs, the servant woman started to wail loudly. She kept hitting her head with her hands while she wailed. 'What madness is this?

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